# Roads? Where We're Going: the movies promised me flying cars, so I kept score

233 films, at least one per release year where a sourced example exists. Each bar runs from release year to the year the film is set in, on humanity's current calendar.

Near future (to 2125)
Far future (compressed scale)
1900 1920 1940 1960 1980 2000 2020 2040 2060 2080 2100 2120
2500 3000 3500 4000 4500 5000
Today (2026)
1910s
Looking Forward (short) 1910 2010 +100 yrs
Pirates of 1920 (short) 1911 1920 +9 yrs
DE Die Große Wette (The Big Bet)* 1916 2000 +84 yrs
The Great Air Robbery 1919 1925 +6 yrs
1920s
The Last Man on Earth* 1924 1950 +26 yrs
DE Metropolis* 1927 2026 +99 yrs
High Treason* 1929 1940 +11 yrs
1930s
Just Imagine 1930 1980 +50 yrs
Men Must Fight 1933 1940 +7 yrs
SU Cosmic Voyage 1936 1946 +10 yrs
Things to Come* 1936 2036 +100 yrs
Buck Rogers (serial) 1939 2440 +501 yrs
1940s
The Shining Future* (short) 1944 1960 +16 yrs
DE The Berliner* 1948 2048 +100 yrs
The House of Tomorrow (short) 1949 2050 +101 yrs
1950s
AT 1. April 2000 1952 2000 +48 yrs
Project Moonbase 1953 1970 +17 yrs
King Dinosaur 1955 1960 +5 yrs
1984 1956 1984 +28 yrs
World Without End 1956 2508 +552 yrs
It! The Terror from Beyond Space 1958 1973 +15 yrs
Queen of Outer Space 1958 1985 +27 yrs
On the Beach 1959 1964 +5 yrs
JP Battle in Outer Space 1959 1965 +6 yrs
1960s
DD/PL The Silent Star* 1960 1970 +10 yrs
Beyond the Time Barrier 1960 2024 +64 yrs
The Time Machine* 1960 802,701 AD (off scale) +800,741 yrs
The Phantom Planet 1961 1980 +19 yrs
DK Journey to the Seventh Planet 1962 2001 +39 yrs
CS Ikarie XB-1 1963 2163 +200 yrs
The Last Man on Earth 1964 1968 +4 yrs
The Time Travelers 1964 2071 +107 yrs
IT/FR The 10th Victim 1965 2079 +114 yrs
Thunderbirds Are Go* 1966 2065 +99 yrs
Daleks' Invasion Earth 2150 A.D. 1966 2150 +184 yrs
THX 1138 4EB* (short) 1967 2187 +220 yrs
2001: A Space Odyssey 1968 2001 +33 yrs
Thunderbird 6* 1968 2068 +100 yrs
Planet of the Apes 1968 3978 +2,010 yrs
FI Time of Roses 1969 2012 +43 yrs
Moon Zero Two 1969 2021 +52 yrs
Journey to the Far Side of the Sun 1969 2069 +100 yrs
1970s
CA Crimes of the Future 1970 1997 +27 yrs
Beneath the Planet of the Apes 1970 3955 +1,985 yrs
Escape from the Planet of the Apes 1971 1973 +2 yrs
The Omega Man 1971 1977 +6 yrs
Conquest of the Planet of the Apes 1972 1991 +19 yrs
Westworld 1973 1983 +10 yrs
Soylent Green 1973 2022 +49 yrs
Sleeper 1973 2173 +200 yrs
Zardoz 1974 2293 +319 yrs
Death Race 2000 1975 2000 +25 yrs
Rollerball* 1975 2018 +43 yrs
A Boy and His Dog 1975 2024 +49 yrs
Futureworld 1976 1985 +9 yrs
Logan's Run 1976 2274 +298 yrs
JP The War in Space 1977 1988 +11 yrs
Libra* (short) 1978 2003 +25 yrs
Alien* 1979 2122 +143 yrs
The Black Hole 1979 2130 +151 yrs
1980s
The Apple 1980 1994 +14 yrs
Escape from New York 1981 1997 +16 yrs
CA Heavy Metal* 1981 2031 +50 yrs
Blade Runner 1982 2019 +37 yrs
Star Trek II: The Wrath of Khan 1982 2285 +303 yrs
IT/FR 2019, After the Fall of New York 1983 2019 +36 yrs
2010: The Year We Make Contact 1984 2010 +26 yrs
PL Sexmission 1984 2044 +60 yrs
JP Bye-Bye Jupiter 1984 2125 +141 yrs
Enemy Mine 1985 2092 +107 yrs
JP Vampire Hunter D 1985 12,090 AD (off scale) +10,105 yrs
The Transformers: The Movie 1986 2005 +19 yrs
Aliens* 1986 2179 +193 yrs
Star Trek IV: The Voyage Home* 1986 2286 +300 yrs
The Running Man 1987 2017 +30 yrs
Alien Nation 1988 1991 +3 yrs
Cherry 2000 1988 2017 +29 yrs
JP Akira 1988 2019 +31 yrs
The Abyss 1989 1994 +5 yrs
Back to the Future Part II 1989 2015 +26 yrs
JP Gunhed 1989 2038 +49 yrs
1990s
Predator 2 1990 1997 +7 yrs
Frankenstein Unbound 1990 2031 +41 yrs
Total Recall* 1990 2084 +94 yrs
Terminator 2: Judgment Day* 1991 1995 +4 yrs
Highlander II: The Quickening 1991 2024 +33 yrs
Star Trek VI: The Undiscovered Country 1991 2293 +302 yrs
Split Second 1992 2008 +16 yrs
Freejack 1992 2009 +17 yrs
AU Fortress 1992 2017 +25 yrs
Nemesis 1992 2027 +35 yrs
Demolition Man 1993 2032 +39 yrs
Timecop 1994 2004 +10 yrs
Star Trek Generations* 1994 2371 +377 yrs
Strange Days 1995 1999 +4 yrs
CA Johnny Mnemonic 1995 2021 +26 yrs
JP Ghost in the Shell 1995 2029 +34 yrs
Tank Girl 1995 2033 +38 yrs
12 Monkeys* 1995 2035 +40 yrs
JP Macross Plus: Movie Edition 1995 2040 +45 yrs
CA Screamers 1995 2078 +83 yrs
Judge Dredd 1995 2139 +144 yrs
Waterworld* 1995 2500 +505 yrs
Escape from L.A. 1996 2013 +17 yrs
Barb Wire 1996 2017 +21 yrs
Star Trek: First Contact* 1996 2063 +67 yrs
The Postman 1997 2013 +16 yrs
Event Horizon 1997 2047 +50 yrs
FR The Fifth Element* 1997 2263 +266 yrs
Soldier 1998 2036 +38 yrs
Lost in Space 1998 2058 +60 yrs
Bicentennial Man* 1999 2005 +6 yrs
The Matrix* 1999 2199 +200 yrs
Wing Commander 1999 2654 +655 yrs
2000s
The 6th Day* 2000 2015 +15 yrs
Mission to Mars 2000 2020 +20 yrs
Battlefield Earth 2000 3000 +1,000 yrs
Titan A.E. 2000 3028 +1,028 yrs
JP Final Fantasy: The Spirits Within 2001 2065 +64 yrs
JP Cowboy Bebop: The Movie 2001 2071 +70 yrs
Ghosts of Mars 2001 2176 +175 yrs
Jason X 2001 2455 +454 yrs
Planet of the Apes (2001) 2001 5021 +3,020 yrs
Reign of Fire 2002 2020 +18 yrs
Minority Report 2002 2054 +52 yrs
Equilibrium 2002 2072 +70 yrs
The Time Machine (2002)* 2002 802,701 AD (off scale) +800,699 yrs
Code 46 2003 2077 +74 yrs
JP Ghost in the Shell 2: Innocence 2004 2032 +28 yrs
I, Robot 2004 2035 +31 yrs
The Island 2005 2019 +14 yrs
CZ A Sound of Thunder 2005 2055 +50 yrs
Æon Flux 2005 2415 +410 yrs
Serenity 2005 2517 +512 yrs
Children of Men 2006 2027 +21 yrs
FR Renaissance 2006 2054 +48 yrs
Idiocracy 2006 2505 +499 yrs
I Am Legend 2007 2012 +5 yrs
Sunshine 2007 2057 +50 yrs
Death Race 2008 2020 +12 yrs
Doomsday 2008 2035 +27 yrs
Repo! The Genetic Opera 2008 2056 +48 yrs
WALL-E* 2008 2805 +797 yrs
Terminator Salvation 2009 2018 +9 yrs
Daybreakers 2009 2019 +10 yrs
Gamer 2009 2034 +25 yrs
Moon* 2009 2035 +26 yrs
BE/CA/FR/DE Mr. Nobody* 2009 2092 +83 yrs
Avatar 2009 2154 +145 yrs
CH Cargo 2009 2267 +258 yrs
2010s
Repo Men 2010 2025 +15 yrs
Tekken 2010 2039 +29 yrs
JP Space Battleship Yamato 2010 2199 +189 yrs
Rise of the Planet of the Apes* 2011 2016 +5 yrs
In Time 2011 2169 +158 yrs
Looper 2012 2044 +32 yrs
FR Lockout 2012 2079 +67 yrs
Prometheus* 2012 2093 +81 yrs
The Purge 2013 2022 +9 yrs
Pacific Rim* 2013 2025 +12 yrs
KR Snowpiercer 2013 2031 +18 yrs
Oblivion 2013 2077 +64 yrs
Elysium 2013 2154 +141 yrs
The Purge: Anarchy 2014 2023 +9 yrs
Dawn of the Planet of the Apes 2014 2026 +12 yrs
RoboCop 2014 2028 +14 yrs
ES/BG Autómata 2014 2044 +30 yrs
Interstellar* 2014 2067 +53 yrs
The Martian 2015 2035 +20 yrs
The Purge: Election Year* 2016 2040 +24 yrs
War for the Planet of the Apes 2017 2028 +11 yrs
Logan 2017 2029 +12 yrs
Blade Runner 2049 2017 2049 +32 yrs
What Happened to Monday 2017 2073 +56 yrs
Alien: Covenant 2017 2104 +87 yrs
Hotel Artemis 2018 2028 +10 yrs
Pacific Rim Uprising 2018 2035 +17 yrs
Isle of Dogs 2018 2038 +20 yrs
Ready Player One 2018 2045 +27 yrs
AU Upgrade 2018 2046 +28 yrs
Terminator: Dark Fate 2019 2020 +1 yr
Avengers: Endgame* 2019 2023 +4 yrs
Captive State* 2019 2027 +8 yrs
FI/DE/BE Iron Sky: The Coming Race 2019 2047 +28 yrs
Alita: Battle Angel 2019 2563 +544 yrs
2020s
Archive STREAM 2020 2038 +18 yrs
The Midnight Sky STREAM 2020 2049 +29 yrs
Underwater 2020 2050 +30 yrs
AU 2067 2020 2067 +47 yrs
RU Cosmoball 2020 2071 +51 yrs
JP The Door into Summer* 2021 2025 +4 yrs
IN Dikkiloona STREAM 2021 2027 +6 yrs
Strawberry Mansion 2021 2035 +14 yrs
Outside the Wire STREAM 2021 2036 +15 yrs
CA/NZ Night Raiders 2021 2044 +23 yrs
The Forever Purge 2021 2048 +27 yrs
The Tomorrow War* STREAM 2021 2051 +30 yrs
Voyagers 2021 2063 +42 yrs
KR Space Sweepers STREAM 2021 2092 +71 yrs
Chaos Walking 2021 2257 +236 yrs
Cosmic Sin 2021 2524 +503 yrs
FR Bigbug STREAM 2022 2045 +23 yrs
Moonshot STREAM 2022 2049 +27 yrs
The Adam Project* STREAM 2022 2050 +28 yrs
HK Warriors of Future 2022 2055 +33 yrs
Avatar: The Way of Water* 2022 2170 +148 yrs
KR The Moon 2023 2029 +6 yrs
Robots STREAM 2023 2032 +9 yrs
CZ/SK/PL/RS Restore Point 2023 2041 +18 yrs
CN The Wandering Earth 2* 2023 2044 +21 yrs
FR/CA The Beast* 2023 2044 +21 yrs
The Creator* 2023 2065 +42 yrs
IN Ganapath 2023 2070 +47 yrs
JP Psycho-Pass Providence 2023 2118 +95 yrs
KR Jung_E* STREAM 2023 2194 +171 yrs
FR Mars Express 2023 2200 +177 yrs
Crater STREAM 2023 2257 +234 yrs
IN Kadaisi Ulaga Por 2024 2028 +4 yrs
Jackpot! STREAM 2024 2030 +6 yrs
Atlas* STREAM 2024 2071 +47 yrs
2073 2024 2073 +49 yrs
RU One Hundred Years Ahead 2024 2124 +100 yrs
Alien: Romulus 2024 2142 +118 yrs
DO/ES Aire: Just Breathe 2024 2147 +123 yrs
IN Kalki 2898 AD 2024 2898 +874 yrs
ID The Siege at Thorn High 2025 2027 +2 yrs
FR/BE Dog 51 2025 2045 +20 yrs
Mickey 17 2025 2054 +29 yrs
FR Arco* 2025 2075 +50 yrs
Absolute Dominion STREAM 2025 2085 +60 yrs
Mercy 2026 2029 +3 yrs
IN Love Insurance Kompany 2026 2040 +14 yrs
ES/AR The Trail of the Wolf 2026 2050 +24 yrs
1900 1920 1940 1960 1980 2000 2020 2040 2060 2080 2100 2120
//
2500 3000 3500 4000 4500 5000

## What I found

- **Set in the past now.** 81 of the 233 films (35%) take place in a year that has already arrived. The median film looks 34 years ahead.
- **About 1 in 5 predictions came true** when near-misses count as half (20.2% of 220 scored forecasts). Only about 1 in 9 came true outright (11.4%).
- **Communication tech won by a mile.** Video calls, flat screens and voice control scored 57.5%, far ahead of any other theme. Society and politics (11%) and transport (13%, from just 12 forecasts) did worst.
- **Bleak futures were no better guides.** Strictly dystopian films scored 19% against 22% for the rest: no meaningful difference (p = 0.14).
- **Gadgets right, catastrophes wrong.** Gadget forecasts scored 41%, but only 2 of 42 plagues, wars and collapses happened (both a second world war, foreseen in 1929 and 1933).

*Headline films (near-misses as half): 2001: A Space Odyssey 35%, Blade Runner 39%, Back to the Future Part II 45% (unchanged). Full figures: stats_summary.md.*

## How I did it

- **Films:** released features (cinema or streaming) set in a named future year on humanity's current calendar, every year sourced. Shorts only fill early gaps; alternate histories and invented calendars are excluded.
- **Setting year:** taken from on-screen dates or official sources; ambiguous, derived or off-screen years are flagged *. Gap = setting year minus release year.
- **Predictions:** the main on-screen technology and society forecasts in the 81 films whose year has arrived, scored came true / sort of / didn't by the setting year (later counts as didn't). Tech that already existed at release and plot devices (time travel, aliens, monsters) are excluded.
- **Checks:** I scored everything myself and checked it twice (a random 40 re-scored: 39 agreed; every hit re-checked; the 44 added in the 233-film update checked line by line, 3 changed). Tone from Wikipedia descriptions, cross-checked with a stricter on-screen rule.
- **Caveat:** these are well-known films that name a year, not a random sample of science fiction, and many groups are small.

*Sources: Wikipedia, AFI Catalog, BFI, SFE, EOFFTV, DEFA, Screen Rant, Smithsonian and press coverage of individual films. See also Wythoff & Leane 2025; Xu et al. 2021.*

STREAM ◇ Streaming-first or streaming-only release (Netflix, Prime Video, digital/VOD); release marker drawn as a hollow diamond

JP Made outside the UK/US (ISO country code; CS = Czechoslovakia, DD = East Germany, SU = Soviet Union)

KR Co-production with the UK/US, led by the country shown (first-listed)

● Release year
● Setting year (near future)
● Setting year (far future)
● Title colour: year ambiguous*

* Ambiguous, derived, or not stated on screen; see films.csv notes. (short)/(serial) = not a single feature.
Sources: Wikipedia, AFI Catalog, BFI, SFE, EOFFTV, DEFA, Screen Rant, Smithsonian. October 2026.